

Urban-Themed Mobile Game Development Plan

This plan outlines how to develop a mobile game inspired by *Monopoly GO* but reimagined with an **urban city-building theme**. The plan integrates urban planning mechanics, modern technologies, and a structured development process. Citations come from urban design articles and interviews with designers of city-themed games.

1. Concept & Market Positioning

- **Game concept** – The game blends casual dice-based progression with a city-building board reminiscent of urban planning. Players roll dice to travel through city blocks, collect resources and build vertically. Each block includes multiple uses (housing, parks, offices, shops) and players must decide how to develop them based on limited space ¹.
- **Target audience** – Casual gamers and city-building fans aged 16–45. Emphasis on family-friendly play to reach younger players, similar to *Kids Build Cities* which encourages discussion about city planning ².
- **Unique selling points** –
 - Real-world urban challenges incorporated into gameplay (e.g., zoning, density, transit).
 - Vertical building mechanic requiring players to stack structures, introducing strategy about height and mixed-use development ³.
 - Event cards modelling urban resilience; players respond to social, ecological or infrastructural events, inspired by *Ekos* design where systems intersect and adaptation cards introduce complexity ⁴.

2. Core Game Mechanics

1. **Board layout** – The board is a map of a fictional city divided into districts, each with distinct land-use profiles. Transit lines (subways or bike-share routes) allow shortcuts and are essential for mobility ⁵. Blocks are smaller than the needs of a full neighborhood, prompting vertical development.
2. **Resource management** – Players gain currency (e.g., “city funds”) by passing certain landmarks or through mini-games. They spend funds to acquire building permits or upgrade structures. Mixed-use towers provide higher returns but require more permits and risk.
3. **Event cards** – Replace traditional chance/community chest with cards that reflect real city events:
4. *Zoning Debate* – players vote on changes; results alter building constraints.
5. *Transit Strike* – reduces movement unless players invest in alternative transit.
6. *Ecological Crisis* – forces investment in green infrastructure; ties into social/ecological systems like in *Ekos* ⁴.

7. **Vertical building mechanic** – Each block has limited area, so players must stack floors. Taller towers yield more revenue but may reduce neighbor satisfaction (shadow or noise complaints). This mirrors vertical building decisions and fosters discussion about density ¹.
8. **Social features** –
9. **Co-operative projects** – players can co-own transit systems or parks, requiring collaboration similar to the systems in *Ekos* where shared ownership is encouraged ⁶.
10. **Heist/Shutdown analogs** – Instead of stealing money, players can “protest” or “redevelop” opponents’ buildings during events, adding tactical interaction.

3. Technology Stack

Layer	Recommended Technologies	Rationale
Game engine	Unity (C#) or Unreal Engine 5 (Blueprints/C++).	Both support rich 2D/3D rendering, physics for dice and buildings, and cross-platform deployment. Unity is popular for mobile and board-game simulations; Unreal excels at 3D visuals.
Client platforms	iOS & Android ; optional WebGL for web.	Cross-platform reach; Unity/Unreal provide tools for mobile and web builds.
Backend services	AWS or Google Cloud Platform (GCP) using Firebase / PlayFab for player accounts, matchmaking, data storage and analytics.	Cloud services handle user authentication, leaderboards, events, and analytics. PlayFab specifically offers game-ready services such as leaderboards and economy management.
Database	NoSQL (e.g., Firestore, DynamoDB).	Flexible schema fits dynamic game items and user inventories; scales with user base.
Multiplayer	Photon Engine or Unity Netcode for GameObjects; Unreal Online Subsystem.	Real-time or turn-based multiplayer functions, essential for co-operative projects and live events.
Analytics	Unity Analytics, Firebase Analytics, or Amplitude.	Provides insight into player behavior, retention and monetization.
Monetization	In-app purchases via Apple/Google stores; rewarded ads using AdMob/Unity Ads; optional season pass or subscription model .	Freemium model similar to <i>Monopoly GO</i> : purchases for extra dice rolls, building permits, special event cards, or cosmetic items.
Development tools	Jira or Trello for agile project management; Figma or Adobe XD for UI/UX design.	Supports iterative development and high-quality interface design.

4. Development Process

1. Concept & Pre-production

2. Conduct detailed market research on city-building games and urban issues.
3. Create a **Game Design Document (GDD)** outlining mechanics, aesthetics and monetization.
4. Perform feasibility analysis and scope; decide 2D vs. 3D visual style. Use concept art inspired by real cities and include local touches like graffiti and street activity ⁷.

5. Prototyping

6. Build a **vertical slice** in Unity or Unreal: implement dice-rolling, board movement, basic building stacking, and one district.
7. Playtest internally to refine the core loop. Ensure functions of buildings and events are intuitively clear; a sense of function is critical for player immersion ⁸.
8. Experiment with event cards and resource balancing; adjust probabilities and effects.

9. Art & User Interface

10. Develop an urban aesthetic with dynamic city backgrounds mixing old and new architecture, reflecting the idea that cities are works in progress ⁹.
11. Use modular environment assets to create distinct neighborhoods with unique landmarks and materials ¹⁰.
12. Create intuitive UI/UX that highlights building permits, vertical floors, and event impacts. Tools like Figma can help iterate prototypes.

13. Core Development

14. Implement all board districts and event card logic.
15. Integrate backend services for player data, in-app purchases and multiplayer features.
16. Add social features: friend lists, co-operative projects, live events, and asynchronous competitions. Incorporate chat or emoji reactions carefully to avoid moderation issues.
17. Add progression systems (levels, achievements, seasonal events) and daily bonuses to encourage habit-forming play.

18. Testing & QA

19. Run continuous integration tests on major platforms (iOS/Android/Web). Use both automated unit tests and extensive manual playtesting.
20. Launch closed alpha/beta tests to gather player feedback. Observe whether players understand urban mechanics and enjoy vertical building. Refine event effects and balancing accordingly.
21. Test server load and performance, particularly around live events and multiplayer interactions.

22. Launch & Marketing

- 23. Soft-launch in select regions to refine user experience and monetization.
- 24. Optimize App Store/Google Play listings (ASO). Use influencer partnerships, social media campaigns and cross-promotions with urban planning communities to attract players.
- 25. Release globally with timed launch events and promotional offers. Monitor analytics to adjust pricing, difficulty and events.
- 26. **Post-launch & Live Operations**
 - 27. Schedule ongoing content updates: new districts, building types, event cards, seasonal themes and limited-time collaborations with real cities.
 - 28. Host live events (e.g., city festivals, climate crises) to encourage player engagement. Use dynamic city changes to reflect the idea that urban spaces evolve ⁹.
 - 29. Gather player feedback and analytics to balance mechanics and add requested features.

5. Cost & Timeline Estimates (High-Level)

Feature Complexity	Timeline	Cost Range (US\$)	Notes
2D vertical slice	3–6 months	\$50K–\$100K	Small team (1–2 developers, artist, designer). Focus on core loop and simple 2D art.
Mid-range 2.5D/3D game	6–12 months	\$150K–\$300K	Add vertical building animations, multiple districts, backend integration and early social features.
Advanced 3D with real-time multiplayer	12–24 months	\$300K–\$600K+	Large team plus backend services. Includes cross-platform play, live events, advanced AI and continuous content updates.

6. Legal Considerations

- **Intellectual property** – Game mechanics (e.g., dice rolling, city building) are not protected by copyright, but artwork, names and rules are ¹¹. Ensure your art style and terminology are original; avoid using Monopoly names or proprietary art.
- **Trademark & licensing** – Trademark the game’s title and distinctive icons. If modelling real cities or buildings, secure permission or use fictional names.

7. Conclusion

An urban-themed adaptation of *Monopoly GO* can offer a fresh experience by blending casual board game mechanics with city-building strategy. By leveraging modern engines like Unity or Unreal, cloud-based backends and a thoughtful development process, the game can deliver engaging gameplay and educational value. Integrating urban planning principles—such as limited space, vertical growth, transit, zoning debates and resilience events—creates depth that resonates with players and sets the game apart in a crowded mobile market.

1 2 3 5 Kids Build Cities, A Toronto Urban Planning Board Game | Designlines Magazine

<https://www.designlinesmagazine.com/kids-build-cities/>

4 6 How do you design a game about urban resilience? | by Urban Systems Lab | Resilience Quarterly | Medium

<https://medium.com/resilience/how-do-you-design-a-game-about-urban-resilience-3cb13eed9961>

7 8 9 10 Urban Design and the Creation of Videogame Cities

<https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/urban-design-and-the-creation-of-videogame-cities>

11 Not Playing Around: Board Games and Intellectual Property Law

https://www.americanbar.org/groups/intellectual_property_law/resources/landslide/archive/not-playing-around-board-games-intellectual-property-law/